— Adi Shankara, *Upadeshasahasri* 11.7[1]

As I have noted earlier, the *Manduka Upanishad* explains that Om is the bow, one's *atman* is the arrow, and Brahman the target. The term Advaita ('not-two') refers to the rejection of dualism: as Shankara's follower, the sage Anandagiri, put it, to say that Brahman and *atman* are separate would be like dividing a fowl in two and saying that one half can be cooked while the other half would lay eggs.

Shankara's Hinduism does not see God as external to the universe. God dwells in the universe, but God is not the universe; He is in it and beyond it. The world is in God, and the two are indivisible. Advaita Vedanta emphasises *jivanmukti*, the idea that *moksha* (salvation or liberation, the realisation of the ultimate purpose of each individual) is achievable in the course of our present life. Advaita's adherents seek their spiritual fulfilment in the acquisition of this profound spiritual knowledge and in immersing themselves in the indissoluble union of the true Self (*atman* or soul) with the highest metaphysical Reality (Brahman).

Shankara also asserted that the realisation of self-knowledge required the mind to be purified by an ethical life that observed essential precepts or Yamas such as *ahimsa* (non-injury, non-violence to others in body, mind and thoughts), *satya* (respect for truth, abstinence from falsehood), *asteya* (rejection of theft), *aparigraha* (abstaining from craving possessions) and a simple life of meditation and reflection. These ideas were to have a profound and lasting impact on Mahtama Gandhi twelve centuries later. (Of *ahimsa*, Gandhi wrote: 'Nonviolence is common to all religions, but it has found the highest expression and application in Hinduism.')

From the ancient texts, Advaita Vedanta accepted the idea of the Purusharthas, the four goals of human life. These, as we have seen earlier, are *dharma*, the right conduct of the individual in accordance with his duties and obligations; *artha*, the material possessions required to sustain the individual and those dependent upon him; *kama*, the pursuit of pleasure and comfort, including love and sexual pleasure; and *moksha*, the individual's ultimate salvation, his liberation from earthly bonds and his realisation of union with the divine spirit. This last